

Try some delicious steaks and sizzlers at the Sizzler Fest at Sidewalk Restaurant. Beat the cold and make the most of this festival till November 24

Indulge in some tasty kebabs at the Swadh Desi festival at S Hotel in JP Nagar. Enjoy the Galouti Kababs and Tandoori tangdi till November 30





QUOTE OF THE DAY

**Morality, like art, means drawing a line someplace**

—Oscar Wilde

CityScape

## FIVE REASONS TO MAKE A DATE IN BENGALURU



### LAUGH RIOT

Have a good laugh at Jurassic Baby comedy show with Crazy Mohan & Maadhu Balaji as they take you through the Superhit Hilarious Comedy Show. The flood gates of humour are opened wide as they crack you up.
**When:** Till December 18, 06:00 pm
**Where:** Bangalore Gayana Samaj, Basuvangudi

### THEATRE

Shaalabhanjike, a 70-minute Kannada play by the Antaranga theatre group is a tale of romance and intrigue set in the time of the Rashtrakuta ruler Dantidurga's rule.
**When:** November 23, 7.30 pm
**Where:** Ranga Shankara, JP Nagar

### TRIBUTE PIECE



Four Strokes' music is a free interpretation of rock n' roll, Blues, country, rock and jazz roots. In this special show, the band will play a tribute concert to one of the biggest bands in the world - The Beatles.
**When:** November 24 (8.30 pm)
**Where:** Hard Rock Cafe, St.Marks Road

### BOOK LAUNCH

*The Agenda of the Apprentice Scientist*, by Nicole Ostrowsky, will be released by Padmashree Dr P Balaram, director of the Indian Institute of Science. The release will be followed by an interactive workshop conducted by the author.
**When:** November 23, 10 am
**Where:** Auditorium, Alliance Francaise, 108 Thimmaiah Road, Vasanthnagar

### SOLO SHOW

*Recollections, Reconnections,* is an exhibition of copper reliefs by artist SG Vasudev.
**When:** Till December 3
**Where:** Kynkyny Art, 104 Embassy Square, 148 Infantry Road

### FOR YOUR LOVED ONE



Make the upcoming festive season count by gifting your loved ones personalised handcrafted items. The *Holiday Season Exhibition* is sure to make your festive season a special one.
**When:** November 26 and 27
**Where:** Raintree, Sankey Road

# Widowed by fate, robbed by babus

**It seems that there are no depths to which officials will plunge, to siphon off welfare scheme monies. This is the story of one woman who was cheated of her money by officials at the tahsildar's office in Kanakapura. How many more have been swindled is anybody's guess**

DC EXPOSE

**AKANKSHA MEHROTRA | DC**
KANAKAPURA, NOV. 22

Every year the State and Union governments roll out dozens of schemes to benefit Below Poverty Line families and spend thousands of crores on the schemes. But does the money or the benefits reach the beneficiary? In most cases, very little or no money reaches those it is meant for.

Investigations carried out by this newspaper clearly show that not even widows are spared when it comes to making a fast buck by the bureaucrats who administer welfare schemes.

Under the National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP), meant to benefit BPL families, the centre has several schemes, one of which is the Indira Gandhi National Widow Scheme under which every BPL widow is supposed to get a one-time payment of ₹10,000.

Just to get this far from generous amount, Chikkataiamma, a widow living in Uiyamballi in Kanakapura taluk, Ramanagara district, has been running from pillar to post, and when she finally got the cheque, it bounced not once but twice.

"My husband, Chikkalinge Gowda passed away on April 30, 2009. As per the Union Government scheme, the family members can seek pension under NSAP within six months of the demise of an earning family member. We had applied for the scheme within two months of his death and submitted a file to tahasildar Chandru containing all the mandatory documents like death certificate, voter ID card, ration card etc. A cheque of ₹10,000 was issued to me on May 31, 2010. Almost a month later, when we deposited the cheque at the State Bank of Mysore, Kanakpura branch, the cheque bounced. The cheque was re-submitted to the same bank on July 6, 2010 and it bounced again," said Chikkathaiamma.

The family decided to approach the Ramanagara District Cooperative Bank for help. The bank deducted ₹ 200 as processing fee and handed over the remaining amount ₹9,800 to the family.

But that was not the end of the matter. "The bank authorities came to our village, threatened us, and took back the money and told us that the cheque has bounced once again. We are poor people. We didn't know what to do. We were told by elders in our village to approach the district deputy commissioner. We approached him with a petition and a copy of the bounced cheque," said Chikkathaiamma.

In the petition copy, the then deputy commissioner of Ramanagaram district instructed the tahasildar to sanction the money immediately to the beneficiary.

"The deputy commissioner told us that the government had sanctioned ₹2 crore under the NSAP scheme and it was supposed to be given to the beneficiaries of the scheme. He also said that the money was dispatched by the government to the tahasildars," she adds.

Just 40 km from the IT capital of Bengaluru, there are several such stories of widows being cheated out of what little the state provides. About 30 families in and around Ramanagaram have met the same fate.

When the beneficiaries approached Chandru with a copy of the petition signed by the deputy commissioner, Chandru promised to issue them new cheques within 15 days. Meanwhile, a case worker, Lakshmi Devi, an assistant of Chandru, approached the 30 affected families and collected the bounced cheques and assured that fresh cheques would be issued within 15 days.

At the end of the 15 days, when Chikkathaiamma's family went to the tahasildar's office, they were shocked to see a new tahasildar. "We came to know that tahasildar Chandru was transferred to some other department and the case worker Lakshmi Devi too was transferred. We approached the new tahasildar, Pragana Hambal, who said that she is not concerned with the issue and we were asked to leave," said a member of Chikkathaiamma's family.

### Mystery deepens

Chikkathaiamma was issued a unique serial number by the government. This number will tell you the status of the money that the Government dispatched under NSAP.

"The unique serial number that we were issued is 06109102332. When we inquired, the status showed that we have received the money! The fact is that the cheque bounced and we were never issued a fresh cheque," says a family member.

### Miseries galore

When the family again approached the new tahasildar of Kanakpura taluk, she said that Chikkathaiamma was not eligible for the scheme. When *Deccan Chronicle* inquired with the present deputy commissioner of Ramanagara district, Puttaswamy, he said: "I have recently taken charge of DC Ramanagara district and I am unaware of the issue."

He sought some time to find out the facts and after speaking to tahasildar Pragana Hambal, he said: "Chikkathaiamma is not eligible to avail this benefit as when her husband passed away, he was 68 years old. The scheme could be availed by the family of a deceased aged between 18-64 years who was employed when he died. It was entirely the responsibility of the former tahasildar, Chandru, to do a background check and then issue the cheque. Action should have been initiated against him but all these practices are very difficult to regulate at the district level. The person was transferred to the Government Secretariat department one year ago."

He concluded saying: "The earlier tahsildar should not have issued the cheques to 30 beneficiaries if there were no funds. The funds are now available and the beneficiaries will get the amount soon."



Chikkataiamma, a BPL widow, shows one of the bounced cheques

### QUESTIONS UNANSWERED

- If the beneficiary was not eligible for the scheme, why was she issued a cheque in the first instance?
- Who has to be held accountable for the mismanagement of funds and inappropriate use of power?
- If the beneficiary did not get the funds, where did the funds actually go?
- Why was no action taken against the former tahasildar Chandru, who is now enjoying his new posting at the Vidhana Soudha?
- What about 29 other widows whose cheques have also bounced?

### WHAT IS IT?

The National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP) which came into effect from August 15,1995, is a significant step towards the fulfilment of the Directive Principles in Article 41 of the Constitution.

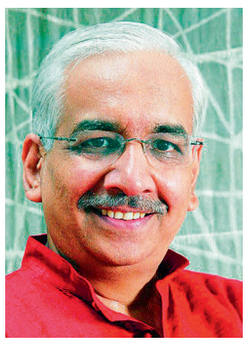
It ensures minimum national standard for social assistance in addition to the benefits that states are currently providing or might provide in future. NSAP, at present, comprises of the Indira Gandhi National Old Age Pension Scheme (IGNOAPS), Indira Gandhi National Widow Pension Scheme (IGNWPS), Indira Gandhi National Disability Pension Scheme (IGNDPS), National Family Benefit Scheme (NFBS) and Annapurna.

### NATIONAL FAMILY BENEFIT SCHEME

- The primary breadwinner will be the member of household male or female whose earning contributes the largest proportion to the total household income.
- The death of such a primary breadwinner should have occurred whilst he or she is in the age group of 18 to 64 years i.e. more than 18 years of age and less than 65 years of age.
- The bereaved household qualifies as one under the poverty line according to the criterion prescribed by the Govt. of India.
- Rs 5,000 in the case of death due to natural causes and Rs 10,000 in the case of death due to accident causes will be the ceilings for purposes of claiming Central assistance.
- The family benefit will be paid to such surviving member of the household of deceased who, after due local enquiry is determined to be the head of the household.
- For the purpose of the scheme, the term "household" would include spouse, minor children, unmarried daughters and dependent parents.



# 'Deposit money directly to beneficiaries' accounts'



**V. RAVICHANDAR**



In such cases, the Unique Identification Authority of India (UIDAI) procedure would work wonders. In a system similar to UID if adopted by the government, money can be directly deposited to the account of beneficiaries. There is no scope of fraudulent practices and beneficiaries will not have to rely on bureaucrats for their dues. A more digitalised way of money transactions should be adopted by the government. In the digital age, manual transactions should be avoided.

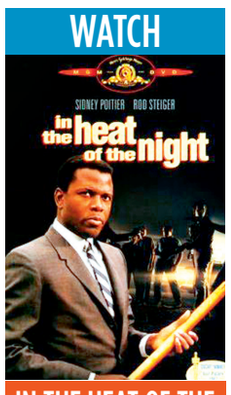
There should be a direct window for BPL families to approach the State Government. Issuing of cheques to the beneficiaries is an old process and makes the beneficiary vulnerable to harassment.

I am sure that the 30 beneficiaries who were issued the cheques that bounced have bank accounts. The government should have taken their account numbers and streamlined the procedure.

Secondly, the State Government should initiate strict action against the official who denied the dues to the beneficiaries. The authorities should set an example by penalising the bureaucrats involved in malpractices so that in future the instances are not repeated. Strict vigil at district level should be adopted by the State Government as scams in smaller areas go unnoticed.

*— The writer is CEO, Feedback Business Consulting Services*

### WATCH




**IN THE HEAT OF THE NIGHT**

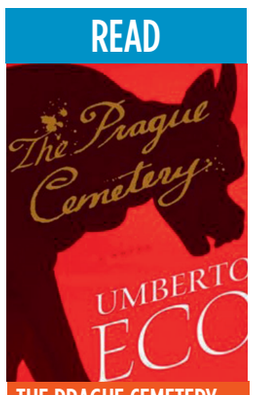
**Cast:** Sidney Poitier, Rod Steiger
**Dir:** Norman Jewison

**A DETECTIVE STRUGGLES WITH RACIAL TENSION**

DETECTIVE VIRGIL TIBBS is caught up in the racial tension of the US South when he is arrested after the murder of a prominent businessman. Tibbs was simply waiting for his next train at the station in Sparta, Mississippi and the confusion is soon resolved but when local police chief Gillespie learns that Tibbs is the Philadelphia PD's number one homicide expert, he reluctantly asks for his assistance. The murdered man, Mr. Colbert, had come to Sparta from the North to build a new factory and his wife and business associates immediately point the finger at Endicott, the most powerful man in the county and the one who had the most to lose if a major new employer comes to the area. Tibbs' life is clearly in danger but he perseveres in a highly charged and racially explosive environment until the killer is found.

***Wednesday, MGM, 8:15pm***

### READ



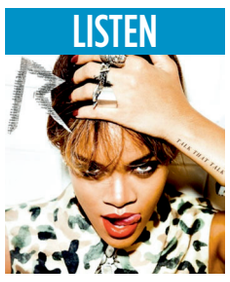

**THE PRAGUE CEMETERY**

**Author:** Umberto Eco
**Publisher:** Houghton Mifflin Harcourt Trade
464pp

**A LOOK AT POLITICS IN THE 19TH CENTURY**

NINETEENTH-CENTURY EUROPE from Turin to Prague to Paris abounds with the mysterious. Conspiracies rule history. Jesuits plot against Freemasons. Italian republicans strangle priests with their own intestines. French criminals plan bombings by day and celebrate Black Masses at night. Every nation has its own secret service, perpetrating forgeries, plots, and massacres. From the unification of Italy to the Paris Commune to the Dreyfus Affair to The Protocols of the Elders of Zion, Europe is in tumult and everyone needs a scapegoat. But what if behind all these conspiracies, lay one lone man? What if that evil genius created its most infamous document? Eco at his most exciting, takes his readers on an unforgettable journey through the underbelly of world-shattering events.

### LISTEN



**TALK THAT TALK**

**By:** Rihanna
**Label:** Def Jam
**Genre:** Pop, R&B

**RIHANNA TALKS THE TALK ONE MORE TIME**

Is there a harder-working pop star than Robyn "Rihanna" Fenty? This year alone, the 23-year-old Bajan singer has released five singles, collaborated with Coldplay, Nicki Minaj and Drake and embarked on a huge worldwide tour. On her off days, she's recorded *Talk That Talk,* her sixth album in seven years, an adrenalised behemoth of a record. It's her most club-ready album to date, fizzing along in a blur of fast-moving electro beats, fearsome synths and lascivious lyrical taunts. Confidence courses through the music in the guttural *Cockiness (Love It).* Rihanna sings as if she is in love with life, and wants to bring us along for the party. She only co-writes four songs on the album, yet each track is indelibly hers through the subtle Caribbean dancehall influences. Only a lone Jay-Z rap on the track *Talk That Talk* briefly bumps Rihanna from centre stage.